BALLON D'OR 2026

Kane won it at 32. The aging curve said he shouldn't have.

0.98

non-penalty goals per 90 2025-26 Bundesliga

0.45

what a typical striker aging curve projected

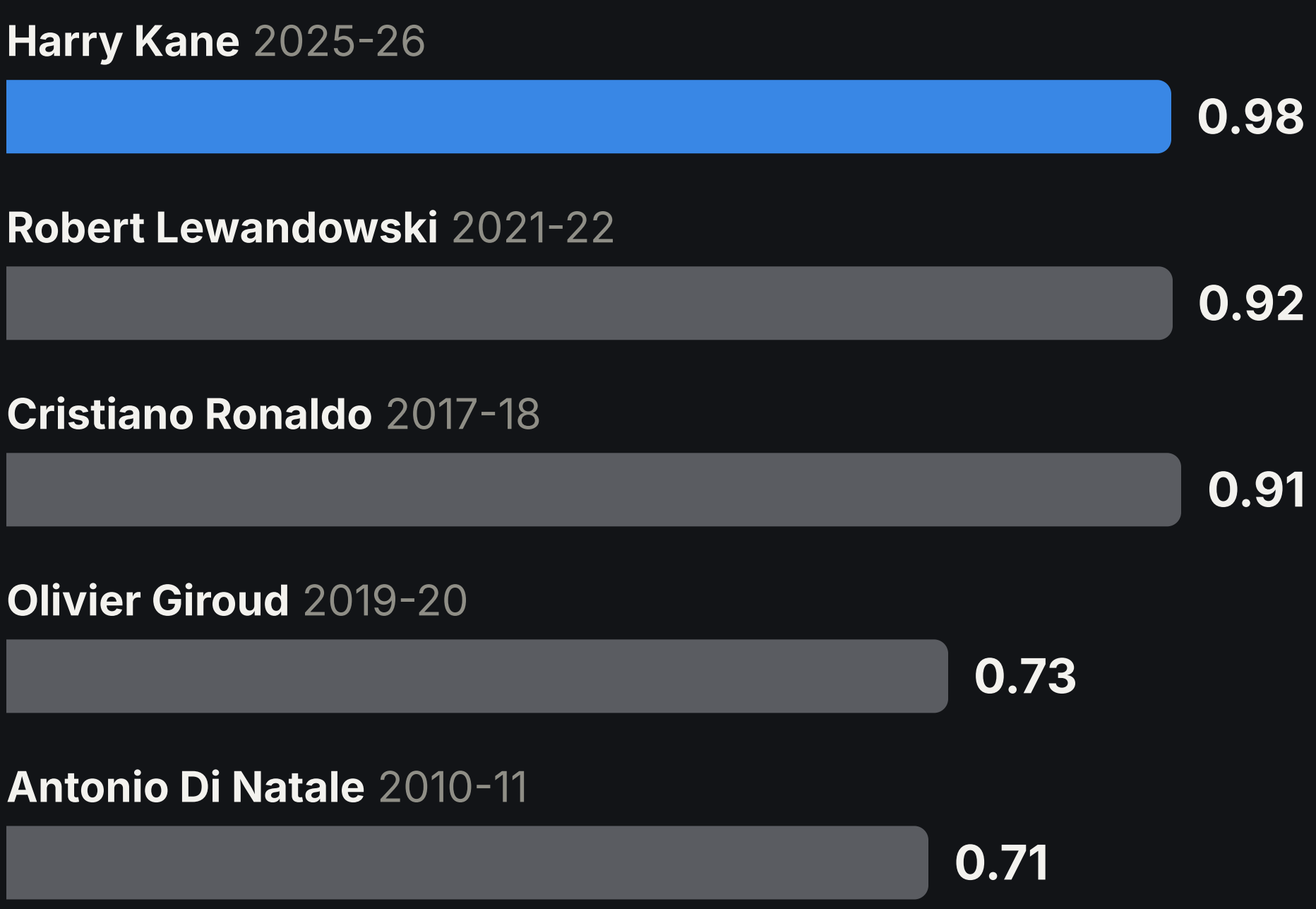
I built aging curves from 6,114 Big 5 forward seasons to find out why. My first theory was wrong.

Swipe →

THE RECORD

Best scoring rate of any forward season started at 32

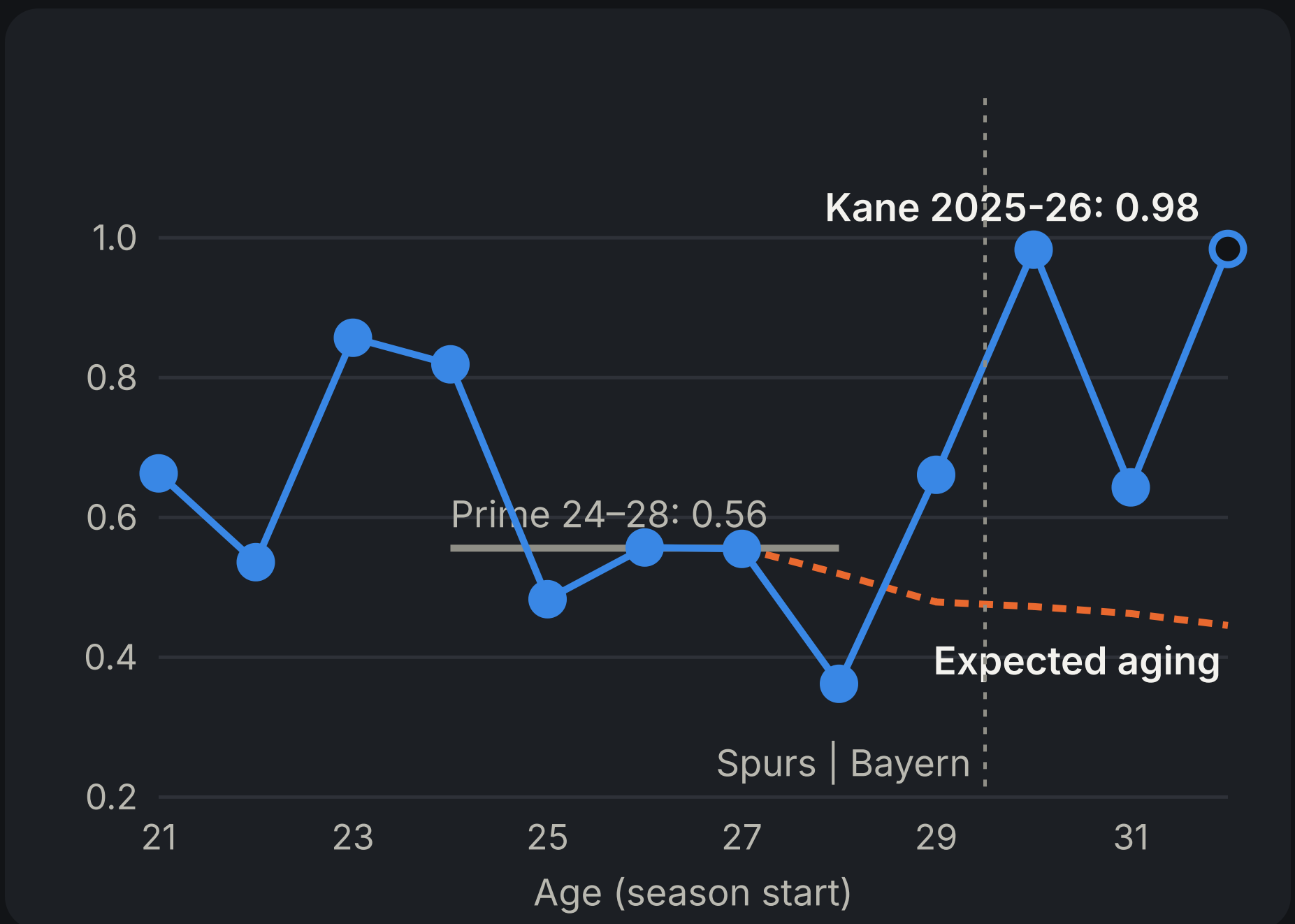
Non-penalty goals per 90, Big 5 leagues since 2009-10.
155 qualifying seasons (900+ minutes).



Kane's 2025-26 from bundesliga.com and StatMuse (36 goals, 10 penalties, 2,377 min).
All other seasons: FBref.

THE GAP

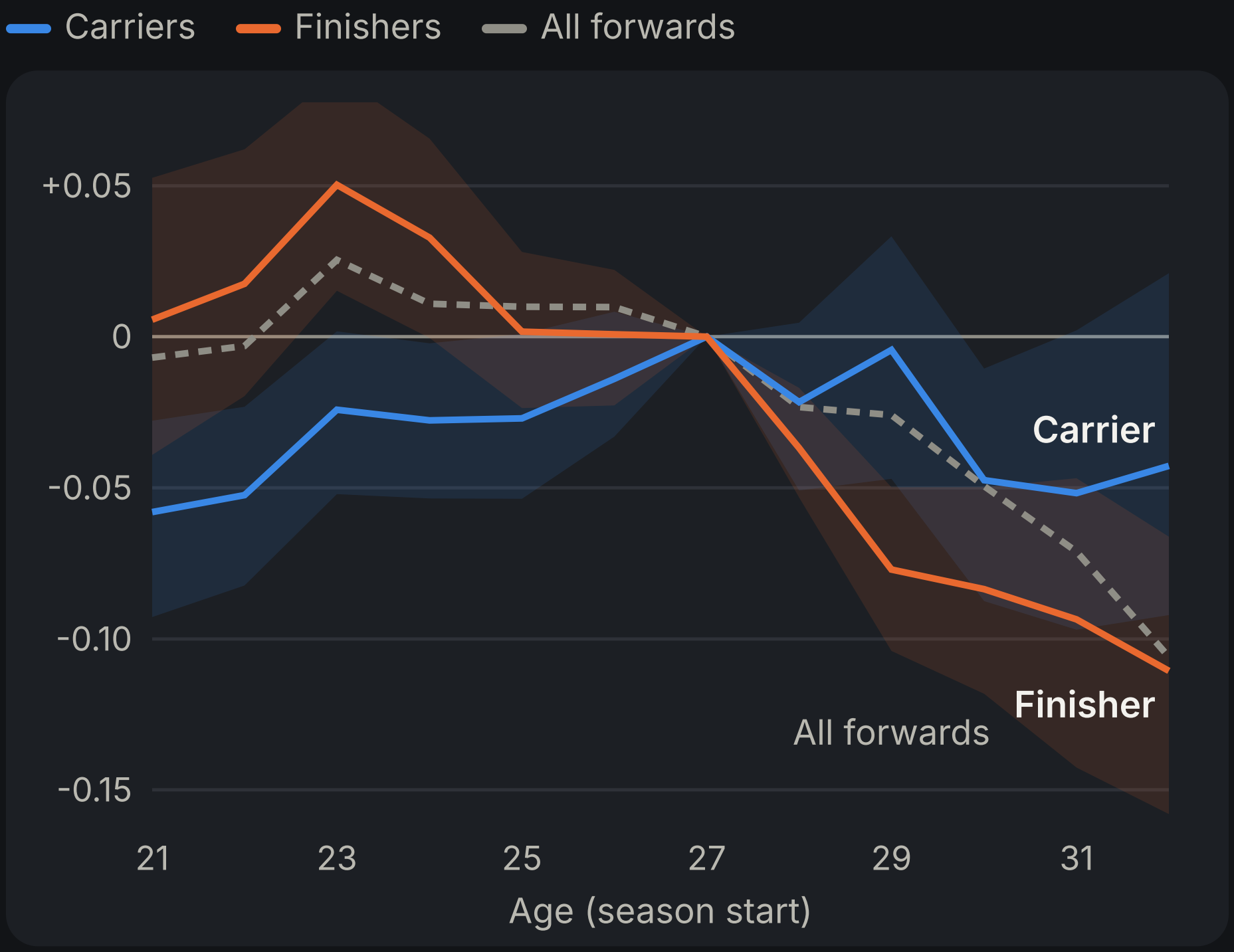
About 14 non-penalty league goals the curve says shouldn't exist



From his Spurs prime of 0.56 per 90 (ages 24–28), aging projected 0.45 at 32. He produced 0.98.

MY THEORY

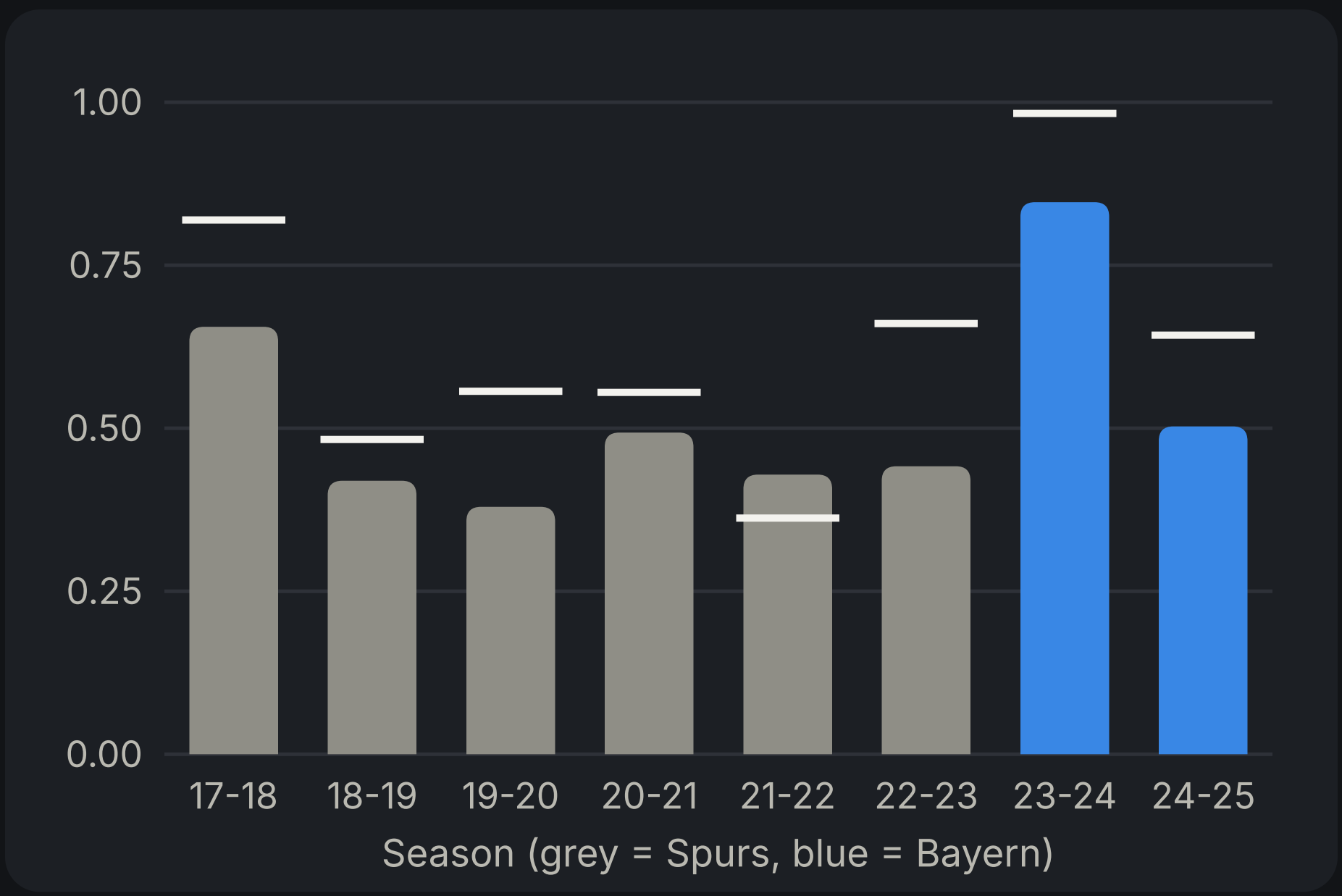
"Finishers age better than dribblers." The data says the opposite.



Low-carry finishers are already down 0.08 per 90 by 29. Carriers are flat. Kane sits at the median on carrying anyway.

WHAT CHANGED

Bayern gave him better chances



npxG per 90 went from 0.47 at Spurs to 0.85 in his first Bayern season. He still beat his xG in 7 of 8 seasons, so the finishing hasn't aged either.

FOR A RECRUITMENT TEAM

Price the environment, not just the age

1. **Model the chance volume he's moving into.**
   A dominant side can more than cancel the decline a curve predicts.

2. **Don't assume poachers age well.**
   In this data, low-carry finishers start dropping around 28.

3. **Two profile buckets aren't enough.**
   Kane's mix of box finishing and deep creation needs its own curve.

METHOD & LIMITS

How it was built

- FBref Big 5 player seasons, 2009-10 to 2024-25. Forwards with 900+ league minutes.
- Delta method: year-over-year change in non-penalty goals per 90, minutes-weighted, chained by age. 80% bootstrap intervals.
- Profiles from take-ons, progressive carries and box carries at ages 29 and under, median split.
- Limits: survivorship bias understates late decline; under 50 players per profile past 31; no team-strength adjustment yet.

Full project, code and data on my GitHub

github.com/colinspel